Blood Spores

a rotting TTRPG by Will Kibel

There is a fungus growing behind your right eye, pushing ever outwards. Soon, it will kill you. Not long after, it will take over the world.

In Blood Spores, you play as a soldier on the front lines of the fight against a volatile fungal infection spreading throughout your corner of the world. This infection takes many forms, and the exact way in which it pervades your reality is up to you. Importantly, however, you have already been infected - and so have many others.

You are an operative for the NFPC (Non-Fungal Preservation Coalition). You have a mission, an objective to complete that will grant you the upper hand against this mycelium. It may be retrieving important research data from a building covered in growth, or thinning out the horde of infected wildlife knocking at your door, or engineering the perfect anti-fungal solution while the hyphae surround you. You may complete the objective - but chances are, the infection will overtake you anyways.

Blood Spores is somewhat mechanics-light, although it borrows some of the framework from Powered by the Apocalypse. However, there is one key mechanic that makes up the core of your existence - you are infected, with a stalk of the mycelium growing behind your right eye, and at any moment you could die.

> As such, every **five real-world minutes**, you must roll 2d6. If you roll a 2, your character **instantly dies**, falling victim to the infection.



How to Play

When creating a character, there are 5 archetypes to choose from: the Bullet, the Needle, the Compass, the Mycologist, and the Fungal. These archetypes all represent different ways of completing objectives for the NFPC, but not necessarily a set personality. They exist to provide structure for your character's actions and skills, not who they are below the surface. Feel free to cross out elements of each character's description if they don't align with your specific character.

In addition, while there is no spot to write down your appearance, that doesn't mean it's unimportant. Make sure the people around you know who you are and what you bring to the table.

Once all characters are made, the game beings. One player, the GM, creates a mission, some objective that will slow or halt the spread of the mycological threat. They give a mission briefing to the players, and assign them the objective together as members of the strike team.

As an operative, you progress via Moves - some of which are listed on your character sheet. Players can also come up with their own moves if the situation calls for it. Different players will specialize in different things, so communication is key. Upon every move, roll 2d6 to see if you succeed or fail.

12 - Critical Success
9-11 - Success
5-8 - Neutral
3-5 - Failure
2 - Critical Failure

In between moves, be sure to examine your environment, talk to your fellow strike team members, or do some introspection. *Anything that does not directly and distinctly contribute to the mission is **free of charge** (and highly discouraged by the NFPC)*.

Over the course of the mission, several obstacles will be thrown at you. Outgun, outwit, outmaneuver, or outgrow whatever comes your way. *Nothing* is more important than the mission. Humanity is depending on you.



Sample Setup

Central Tower has been replaced. It happened slowly, but a massive stalk has grown through the center, pushing through concrete and steel, overtaking the entire building. Now, an enormous fungal monolith looms over the city, shedding spores by the thousands every day. Your mission is to traverse down into the earth, to the very bottom of the central stalk and burn it, taking out the monolith from its base. It is almost certainly a suicide mission.

As you go, your connection to the hive mind deepens. Your hallucinations start becoming more real, and reality starts becoming more dangerous. Enormous hulking brutes patrol the lower levels, amalgamates of human flesh brought together by the unifying myceloid. Scanners roam the passageways, their tendrils connecting the stalk to the outside world, to all who may breach its haven. Your right eye tickles.

Armed with a flamethrower and a few molotov cocktails, your team's descent takes you deeper than you've ever gone before into the heart of the fungus. The only question is: will you return? Or will something else entirely?



THE BULLET

a weapons expert. the rifle and the projectile. crisp, clean, precise. covert. a specialist.

[ ][ ][ ][ ][ ][ ]

mark 1 Infection to allow the stalk in your eye to creep forward. change a roll to a 12 or avoid all harm from an injury. if all Infection is marked, the fungus overtakes you.

*there is no salvation at the end of the road. you fought the good fight, you tell yourself. all you can do is sacrifice your life for something or someone. you **must** die completing the objective.*

GEAR

pick 4 of the following:

- ☐ *flashlight*
- ☐ *old-fashioned revolver*
- ☐ *map of the objective*
- ☐ *EMP grenade*
- ☐ *machete*

*the world is covered in mold and decay. it pervades every surface, every loose strand of life. what have **you** lost?*

MOVES

- attack
- condemn
- strategize
- proceed forward

JOURNAL

THE NEEDLE

a healer. methodical, detail-oriented. kind and calculated. well-learned. scientific. a doctor.

[ ][ ][ ][ ][ ][ ]
mark 1 Infection to allow the stalk in your eye to creep forward. change a roll to a 12 or avoid all harm from an injury. if all Infection is marked, the fungus overtakes you.

*"do no harm." your knowledge can heal or destroy, salve or burn. but the rot grows ever inside of you now. physician, heal thyself. you **must** die completing the objective.*

GEAR

pick 3 of the following:

- ☐ *antidote*
- ☐ *stethoscope*
- ☐ *deadly toxin*
- ☐ *lighter*

*the world is covered in mold and decay. it pervades every surface, every loose strand of life. what have **you** lost?*

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

MOVES

- help another
- commit malpractice
- remember something important
- proceed forward

JOURNAL

_____

THE COMPASS

a magnet. a navigator. good at knowing things like the back of one's hand. cool-headed. observant.

[ ][ ][ ][ ][ ][ ]

mark 1 Infection to allow the stalk in your eye to creep forward. change a roll to a 12 or avoid all harm from an injury. if all Infection is marked, the fungus overtakes you.

you've seen it all, the vast swaths of land covered in hyphae. the people, clawing at their chitinous eyes. you've seen it and done nothing.
*you **must** die completing the objective.*

GEAR

pick 3 of the following:

- ☐ *compass*
- ☐ *binoculars*
- ☐ *smoke grenade*
- ☐ *notebook and pencil*

*the world is covered in mold and decay. it pervades every surface, every loose strand of life. what have **you** lost?*

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

MOVES

- choose a path
- scout ahead
- observe and learn
- check your surroundings
- proceed forward

JOURNAL

_____

THE MYCOLOGIST

a weapons expert. the rifle and the projectile. crisp, clean, precise. covert. a specialist.

[ ][ ][ ][ ][ ][ ]

mark 1 Infection to allow the stalk in your eye to creep forward. change a roll to a 12 or avoid all harm from an injury. if all Infection is marked, the fungus overtakes you.

*your studies have finally caught up to you. the clues were always there. you weren't blind, just apathetic. you saw the tendrils as they grasped. you **must** die completing the objective.*

GEAR

pick 3 of the following:

- ☐ *guide book*
- ☐ *spore sample*
- ☐ *UV flashlight*
- ☐ *flamethrower*

*the world is covered in mold and decay. it pervades every surface, every loose strand of life. what have **you** lost?*

MOVES

- analyze a sample
- bury your curiosity
- withhold information
- take a sample for yourself
- proceed forward

JOURNAL

THE FUNGAL

y o u h a v e n o t i m e l e f t
y o u a r e a l m o s t g o n e
i n f e c t e d

[ ][ ][ ][ ][ ][ ]
mark 1 Infection to allow the stalk in your eye to creep forward. change a roll to a 12 or avoid all harm from an injury. if all Infection is marked, the fungus overtakes you.

*more mold than human, you are all but converted. your value as an asset just barely outweighs the imminent threat you pose to those around you. you **must** die completing the objective.*

GEAR

pick 3 of the following:

- ☐ *bioluminescence*
- ☐ *spore cloud*
- ☐ *chitin shield*
- ☐ *tendrils*

*the world is covered in mold and decay. it pervades every surface, every loose strand of life. what have **you** lost?*

MOVES

- *c o n s u m e*
- *g r o w*
- *s p r e a d*
- *c o m m u n e*
- *p r o c e e d*

JOURNAL